

BLOOM IN THE DESERT

Gujarat is witnessing a grassroots water revolution. Every village and town of the state is becoming a part of the successful implementation of Jal Jeevan Mission that aims to provide 100% tap water connections to the nation by 2024

It is rightly said that Jal hi Jeevan hai (life is inconceivable without water). Even as we are celebrating 75 years of Independence, equitable access to clean and potable water in both rural and urban areas remains a key critical challenge. The Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM), a central government initiative under the Ministry of Jal Shakti, aims to ensure access of tap water to every household in India. Based on a community approach to water, the mission has gone on to create a people's movement for water, making it everyone's priority.

In his Independence Day speech, 2019 Prime Minister Narendra Modi highlighted that half of the country's households did not have access to tap water. Earmarking ₹ 3.5 trillion for JJM, he said the Centre and states would work towards meeting this challenge in coming years.

DRINKING WATER CRISIS IN INDIA

According to the NITI Aayog's Composite Water Management Index (CWMI) 2018, 21 Indian cities could face Day Zero in the coming years. Day Zero refers to the day when a place is likely to have no drinking water of its own. Bengaluru, Chennai, Delhi and Hyderabad are among the most susceptible. The report also said that 75% of Indian households do not have drinking water on- premises and about 84 per cent rural households do not have piped water access.

Moreover, water is not properly distributed where it is supplied through pipes. Mega cities like Delhi and Mumbai get more than the standard municipal water norm of 150 litres per capita per day (LPCD) while others get 40-50 LPCD.

MISSION DERIVED FROM WATER SUPPLY MODEL OF GUJARAT

The visionary JJM, announced by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on 15th August 2019 from the ramparts of Red Fort, is derived from the water supply model of Gujarat, which is a matter of pride for the Water Supply Department, Government of Gujarat.

Gujarat, earlier suffered from acute paucity of water. Even though it received ample rainfall, due to the challenging topography, water was either washed away or dried up. Shri Narendra Modi, who was then the chief minister of Gujarat, took it up as a challenge, paving the way for a transformation of the water scenario in the state. He designed the 'Water Grid' that connected Gujarat with a strategic water supply grid. This grid was so effective that it reached water to the farthest regions of Gujarat such as Kutch. Later, water reached the hilly regions of Dangs in the south. It also served the needs of North Gujarat regions such as Banaskantha and Surendranagar which faced severe water scarcity at that time.

- *Har Ghar Nal Se Jal,* a crucial part of the JJM, was announced by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman in her Budget 2019-20 speech.
- The programme aims to implement source sustainability measures as mandatory elements, such as recharge and reuse through grey water management, water conservation, and rain water harvesting. Gram panchayats have also come forward to ensure effective and speedy implementation of the mission.
- Residents have been trained to implement the programme and ensure equitable water supply in their villages.

STUDIES IN TRANSFORMATION

Kanakpar and Takhatgadh villages have received National Water Awards. Here is a quick look at their achievements:

Kanakpar village of Kutch district was a drought prone area. The water in the village was non-potable and the quality was